Leakages, I was often reminded, is not a uniquely Indian problem. As we made moves in various scientific fields, from semiconductors and renewables to drones and aircraft technology, a tech-friendly PM contributed to the perception of India as a trusted collaborator.

There are some issues that could be put in the category of core beliefs. Standing up to terrorism would certainly rank high among them. After my initial exposure to that in Beijing in 2011, whenever the occasion warranted, it was made abundantly clear that we would not allow cross-border terrorism to be normalized under any circumstances. When Uri happened in 2016, there was little doubt among us internally that we would respond in a fitting manner. I was not in government during Balakot in 2019 but can only say that it was very much in keeping with character. At the UN, we have consequently pushed strongly for sanctioning of terrorists. And when others have sought to block it for some political objective, there has been no hesitation in calling them out publicly. As a member of the UN Security Council (UNSC) in October 2022, we organized a meeting of the Counter Terrorism Committee (CTC) in Mumbai at one of the venues of the 26/11 terror attack. India has also been a strong votary of initiatives like ‘No Money for Terror’. From a foreign policy perspective, it is, of course, always advantageous to be functioning with clear objectives and firm instructions. This was also the case when it came to engaging the world on the Article 370 issue. A nationalist outlook will naturally produce a nationalist diplomacy, and it is something that the world will need to get used to.

Economic priorities at home will always be a powerful driver of policies abroad. Enabling the flow of resources and absorbing best practices have acquired even greater priority in recent years. In many ways, PM Modi has led from the front by engaging entrepreneurs, visiting technology centres and seeking to promote innovation and skills. In all of this, employment creation and talent promotion remain his focus. His travels abroad often feature visits to institutions and activities that are relevant to our national flagship programmes. One can sense a strong determination to accelerate India’s growth and build further its comprehensive national power. On occasion, it can mean going against orthodox thinking and global mantras. A relevant case was that of joining the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) in 2019. Despite considerable pressure, PM Modi took the courageous call to not accede. Since then, that decision has been more